

IT IS TIME TO PUT 2020 IN THE REARVIEW MIRROR

TEXT: Philippians 3:13-14 (NKJV) *“Brethren, I do not count myself to have apprehended; but one thing I do, forgetting those things which are behind and reaching forward to those things which are ahead, ¹⁴ I press toward the goal for the prize of the upward call of God in Christ Jesus.”*

INTRO: When I reflect on 2020, I cannot help but think of the old adage by Charles Dickens, *“It was the best of times and the worst of times.”* There is no way any of us could have predicted on the last Sunday of 2019, everything that the world would encounter in 2020. We ended 2019:

- Hopeful...
- Ready for a fresh start...
- Excited for a new decade...
- Looking for our lives to improve...
- Making changes that were badly needed...

- Setting goals that would move us into a better place...

Then Covid 19 introduced itself in March of 2020! With the arrival of this worldwide pandemic (Planned-Demic – With love from China), came many hurdles none of us have ever encountered in our lifetimes. Over the last ten months we have faced:

- Disease...
- Sickness...
- Shutdowns...
- Joblessness...
- Quarantine...
- Uncertainty...

Add to this, a national election in the middle of the chaos, created by the planned-demic! As may be expected in such an off-the-rails-year, the elections themselves are yet to be fully settled, almost two months after the fact!

Do all these things make you concerned for your children and grandchildren? People are asking questions like:

- What will happen next?
- Is this the end of the world?
- Will we be able to survive what is coming next?
- Will there be a future for our children and grandchildren?

These are legitimate questions, and the answer is subjective. For those who have placed their trust in Jesus, we can rest assured that everything is going to be alright. This doesn't mean that we will not face some challenging things – This means He has promised to ***“Never leave us or forsake us – to go with us to the end of the world!”*** For Christ followers, this is the best of times!

For those who have not placed their trust in Jesus, you are right to be afraid! For those who are not following Jesus, it is the worst of times.

It is time to put 2020 in the rearview mirror!

How can we move from a year like 2020, and have faith for better days ahead in the New Year? Paul explains how this can occur.

FORGETTING THOSE THINGS WHICH ARE BEHIND!

Not everything in 2020 has been negative. Some great things that have happened in 2020 include:

- We are still here... Some have been sick, and a few are in Heaven, but we are still here!
- A new campus is ready to be launched from CT Houston... Have Roger and team to stand. We will be blessing these folks on January 10, and they will launch on January 17.
- A new Saving Grace site is being launched in Baker Florida... Just west of Pensacola – Near Crestview – Someone gave \$410,000 to make this a reality

- CT Church has paid off more than one million dollars in debt in 2020...
- CT tithe has been down about 2.7% but our net income has been almost \$400,000

I really have faith that better things are ahead for the church and the ministry – as well as those who will put Jesus first, and follow Him implicitly. ***“Heaven and earth will pass away, but my words will not pass away.”***

Paul admonishes us to ***“Forget those things which are behind...”*** The challenge for us is to:

- Forget the negative things... “It has been the worst of times...”
- Forget the successes... If we are going to put 2020 in the rearview mirror and step confidently by faith into the New Year, to some degree, we must forget our past successes. (Success is only success if we build on what has been accomplished)

It is time to put 2020 in the rearview mirror!

Paul continued on...

REACHING FORWARD TO THOSE THINGS WHICH ARE AHEAD

Once we put the failures, and to some degree, the successes of the past, in the rearview mirror, we must, “*Reach forward to those things which are ahead.*” How do we do this? By setting God inspired goals for the future. Christ followers are futuristic people. We do not:

- Wallow in the failures of the past...
- Remain fixated on the events of the past...
- Remain stuck in the successes of the past...

Christ followers:

- Move into the future by faith...
- Step up to the challenges of the future with confidence...
- Continue marching forward in the anointing of Holy Spirit...

Because we are futuristic people, we set God inspired goals that do not allow for failure. One cannot, “*Reach for the things that are before*” without setting God inspired goals. Have we set our goals for 2021? If not, why not?

Goal setting is a natural part of “*Reaching for the things that are before.*” There are three components to goal setting: (The goal of CT Church is to get ready to launch two new campuses in 2021 – Launch date January 2022)

- Immediate goals... These are easily achievable, short-term goals – Quick wins! (Our immediate goal will be to identify two qualified leaders, who can successfully lead our church planting efforts)
- Intermediate goals... (Our intermediate goal will be to convince these leaders to join our efforts – Part of this goal will be to coach and train these leaders to launch and lead successfully)

- Ultimate goals... (Our ultimate goal is a healthy leader and a healthy church – Churches planting churches)

Put 2020 in the rearview mirror by setting your own:

- Immediate goals...
- Intermediate goals...
- Ultimate goals...

It is time to put 2020 in the rearview mirror!

Paul concludes his comments by saying...

PRESS TOWARD THE GOAL – THE UPWARD CALL OF GOD

The Greek word used for “*Press*” here is, “*Diwkw*” (Dee-o-ko), and means “*To pursue.*” Some years ago, while telling the Lord how much I loved Him and desired his work in my life, He spoke to me and said, “*The proof of desire is pursuit.*” We have as much of Jesus as

we desire! We will reach the goals that we pursue in 2021.

CONCLUSION:

Paul is saying, “*The future belongs to those who forget the past; those who reach forward by faith; and those who pursue the upward call of God.*”

If God is our partner:

- Are we thinking right?
- Are we dreaming big enough?
- Are we acting like Chicken Little or Superman?

The “*Upward call of God*” is:

- Something bigger than what we can do ourselves...
- Something bigger than our group can accomplish...
- Something bigger than our circles of influence will be able to pull off...

Put 2020 in the rearview mirror and reach for something big in 2021!